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"ODISHA'S NEXT DECADE WILL BE ABOUT THE YOUTH"

Former IAS officer and now Biju Janata Dal leader **V.K. Pandian,** who heads Odisha's revolutionary 5T (transparency, technology, teamwork, time and transformation) model of governance, spoke to Group Editorial Director (Publishing) **Raj Chengappa**, on how the initiative is changing citizens' experience for the better. Excerpts from the interview



V.K. Pandian, *Chairman, 5T (Transformational Initiatives) and Nabin Odisha*

Q. How did the principle of 5T evolve? How is it implemented? For instance, how did 5T help in the execution of the Shree Jagannatha Temple *parikrama* project?

A. When CM Naveen Patnaik won his fifth term, he did not want to make just changes to Odisha but transform the state... Benchmarks were set for every sector. And he was ready to pay some political cost, if required, to achieve this. The 5T principle is the foundation of this goal. It was at play at Shree Jagannatha Temple *parikrama* project. It was a complete teamwork involving various departments, *sevayats*, people's representatives, the Gajapati Maharaja and the Shree Jagannatha Temple Administration. But more importantly, as the CM says, it's God's wish. He wanted the temple to be renovated at this time and by our CM. So, it happened.

Q. Odisha has turned around government schools with a big leap in the quality of education and infrastructure. How did that come about?

A. Around 70-80 per cent of the children are dependent on government schools. If the state has to reach the next level, these 70 per cent should be empowered to dream big and achieve their dreams. This can happen when you give them smart classes, science labs, the best of equipment and sports facilities.... We consciously selected high schools to start with.... We are the only state in the country to have transformed all 8,650 high schools. Not just physical transformation, we have also re-engineered the entire curriculum, the software component, life skills and attitude.

Q. Naveen Patnaik is on his way to making history by becoming India's longest-serving CM. What is his success mantra and management style?

A. It's very simple. What Lord Krishna said in the Bhagavad Gita: Do your work and leave everything to God. The CM has no expectations. He is using politics as a medium to serve people, not vice versa. And that is the reason he is so popular. The day he thinks that people do not appreciate his public service, he will quit politics. He does not hang on to any post or power or politics.

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Q. If CM Patnaik gets a sixth term, what are you going to achieve through 5Ts in the next term?

A. In 2036, Odisha will be celebrating 100 years of statehood. The CM has given us a deadline for developing the state by 2034 so that we have a buffer of two years in case we miss some targets. It's a 10-year deadline, which means two five-year terms. This is going to be the golden period for Odisha. We have a clear road map as to how the people should aspire for a new and empowered Odisha and how it will be transformed into a new and empowered Odisha. In the last 24 years, he has delivered in terms of poverty alleviation, ending corruption, disaster management, food security, irrigation and women empowerment. Now is the time for the youth. We are planning to have a youth budget. We will make them more competitive, more able to achieve their dreams. ■